Cruise Ship Pianist Rescued After Nine Hours in the Pacific

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Two fishermen off the coast of California spotted something surprising in the water about 20 miles from shore: a man, **treading** water, all alone in the Pacific Ocean.

'Yeah, it's a human being. Stop the boat; let's get all of our lines in,' Grant Garrett recalled saying when he and fellow fisherman Sean Norton spotted him.

The man told them he was a **pianist** on the Ovation of the Seas, a 14-deck **cruise** ship. He had been in the water for about nine hours. 'The only thing he said to me was, 'Thank you. I thought I was gonna die,'' Norton said.

The fishermen pulled him from the water and called for help. The Coast Guard said it received a report from 'a Good Samaritan who recovered a conscious individual from the water.' The man was handed over to Newport Beach **Lifeguards**, who confirmed he was an employee of the Ovation of the Seas.

Norton said the man was lucky in one big way: the ocean was unusually warm. The water was 76 degrees Fahrenheit, about 24 degrees Celsius. 'You have this crazy super **El Niño** year,' Norton said. 'A different year, no way he makes it.'

El Niño is a climate pattern that warms the waters of the Pacific. Scientists monitoring the Pacific say this one is now the strongest on record, with ocean temperatures about 3.05 degrees Celsius above average.

How the **pianist** ended up in the water is not clear. The **cruise** line said it would share no further details, 'to respect the privacy of our employee.' What is clear is that two fishermen in the right place at the right time, and a very warm ocean, helped save his life.

Word Treasure

treading -- Staying afloat in water by moving your arms and legs.
pianist -- A person who plays the piano.
El Niño -- A climate pattern that warms the waters of the Pacific Ocean.
lifeguards -- Trained people who rescue swimmers in trouble in the water.
cruise -- A holiday trip on a very large ship.

Background you need

A cruise ship is a very large ship that carries passengers on holiday, with restaurants, pools and entertainment on board.

Treading water means staying afloat by moving your arms and legs, which is tiring and hard to keep up for long.

El Niño is a climate pattern that warms the waters of the Pacific Ocean, making sea temperatures higher than usual.

Lifeguards and the Coast Guard are trained rescuers who help people in trouble in the sea.

Break it down

LEAD: Two fishermen rescued a cruise ship pianist who had spent about nine hours treading water in the Pacific.

KEY EVENT: Grant Garrett and Sean Norton spotted the man about 20 miles off the California coast and pulled him from the water.

+- WHO: The fishermen, the pianist from the Ovation of the Seas, the Coast Guard and Newport Beach Lifeguards.

+- WHEN: He had been in the water for about nine hours when they found him.

EVIDENCE: The Coast Guard said a 'Good Samaritan' recovered a conscious individual, and lifeguards confirmed he worked on the ship.

OPEN QUESTION: How did the pianist end up in the water? The cruise line will not say, to protect his privacy.

Why it matters

This story shows how being in the right place at the right time can save a life, and how the weather and the ocean can make the difference between danger and survival.

Test what you remember

1. Who spotted the man in the water?

(A) Two fishermen, Grant Garrett and Sean Norton
(B) A helicopter crew
(C) The Coast Guard
(D) A cruise ship captain

2. How far from shore was the man?

(A) About 20 miles
(B) About 200 miles
(C) About 2,000 miles
(D) About 2 miles

3. How long had the man been in the water?

(A) About nine hours
(B) About nine weeks
(C) About nine minutes
(D) About nine days

4. What was the man's job?

(A) A lifeguard
(B) A Coast Guard officer
(C) A fisherman
(D) A pianist on the Ovation of the Seas

5. Why did the warm water matter?

(A) It helped him survive nine hours in the sea
(B) It made the fish bite more
(C) It pushed him toward shore
(D) It made the rescue boat faster

6. What is El Niño?

(A) A storm in California
(B) A type of cruise ship
(C) A kind of fish
(D) A climate pattern that warms the Pacific

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: A 4: D 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Fisherman Sean Norton: He says the man was lucky because the ocean was unusually warm, and that in a different year he would not have made it.

2. The cruise line: It says it will share no further details, to respect the privacy of its employee.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):